

CHAPTER FOUR

THE ELEMENTS OF MAGIC

The 'elements' within magical symbolism are the basic components of all that exists. These four elements—Earth, Air, Fire and Water—are at the same time visible and invisible, physical and spiritual.

From these elements all things have been fashioned, according to magical thought. Our current scientific knowledge, which states that there are many more such 'building blocks', isn't unharmonious with this statement, but is merely a more refined version.

It is unwise to view the four elements in purely physical terms. Earth, for example, refers not only to the planet on which we exist, but also to the phenomenon of earthiness, of foundation and stability. Similarly, Fire is much more than flame.

While there are many attributes to these elements which are out of place in this chapter, a few words on each of them and why they are important in magical workings is necessary.

Since this is the magic of nature, using natural powers, tools and symbols, it is important to understand these powers. One of the ways this can be achieved is through the study of the elements.

The elemental system was devised and refined in the Renaissance, but its roots stretch farther back into history. It can be

viewed as nothing more than a convenient system of organization for the various types of magic. Then again, it may be viewed as a very real system of powers which can be called upon to aid spells and rituals. How you view them is up to you.

The following discussions deal with the symbolism of and types of magic related to the elements. All of the magic contained within this book falls under the rulership of one (or more) of the elements. This is true, too, of all that exists.

An understanding of them will aid your magical work immensely.

Though the elements are described as 'masculine' or 'feminine', this should not be viewed in a sexist way. This, like all magical systems, is symbolic—it describes the basic attributes of the elements in terms easily understandable. It doesn't mean that it is more masculine to perform fire magic, or more appropriate for women to use water magic. It's simply a system of symbols.

EARTH

This is the element we are closest to home with, since it *is* our home. Earth doesn't necessarily represent the physical Earth, but that part of it which is stable, solid, dependable.

Earth is the foundation of the elements, the base. It is in this realm that most of us live a good part of our lives. When we walk, sit, stand, crawl, eat, sleep, work our jobs, tend our plants, balance our checkbooks or taste salt we are working within the element of Earth.

Earth is the realm of abundance, prosperity, and wealth. While it is the most physical of the elements this is not negative, for it is upon earth that the other three rest. Without Earth, life as we know it could not exist.

In magical workings Earth 'rules' all spells and rituals involving business, money, employment, prosperity in all its forms, stability, fertility and so on.

A ritual of this element could be as simple as burying an object representative of your need in a plot of virgin ground, walking over miles of countryside visualizing your need, or drawing images in dirt.

Earth is a feminine element. It is nurturing, moist, fruitful, and it is these qualities which make it feminine. Such attributes have impelled countless civilizations to envision the Earth as a great Mother Goddess, the all-fertile Creatress of nature.

Earth rules the Northern point of the compass, because that is the place of greatest darkness and of winter. Its color is the green of the fields and plants.

It governs stone, image, tree and knot magic.

AIR

Air is the element of the intellect; it is the realm of thought, which is the first step toward creation.

Magically speaking, air is the clear, uncluttered, pure visualization which is a powerful tool for change. It is also movement, the impetus that sends the visualization out toward manifestation.

It rules spells and rituals involving travel, instruction, freedom, obtaining knowledge, discovering lost items, uncovering lies, and so on.

It can also be used to develop the psychic faculties.

Spells involving air usually include the act of placing an object in the air or dropping something off the side of a mountain or other high place so that the object actually connects physically with the element.

Air is a masculine element, being dry, expansive, and active. It is the element that excels in places of learning, and which is at work while we theorize, think, and ponder.

Air rules the East because this is the direction of the greatest light, and the light of wisdom and consciousness. Its color is yellow, the yellow of the Sun and of the sky at dawn, and its season is spring.

Air governs the magic of the four winds, most divinations, concentration and visualization magic.

FIRE

Fire is the element of change, will and passion. In a sense it

contains within it all forms of magic, since magic is a process of change.

Fire magic can be frightening. The results manifest quickly and spectacularly. It is not an element for the faint-hearted. However, it is most primal and for this reason is much used.

This is the realm of sexuality and passion. It is not only the 'sacred fire' of sex, it is also the spark of divinity which shines within us and in all living things. It is at once the most physical and spiritual of the elements.

Its magical rituals usually involve energy, authority, sex, healing, destruction (of negative habits, disease), purification, evolution, and so on.

A ritual of Fire usually involves the fuming, burning or smouldering of an image, herb, or other flammable object, or the use of candles or small blazes.

Its magic is usually practiced near the hearth, or beside fires lit in wilderness clearings, or beside the flame of a single candle.

Fire is masculine. It rules the South, the place of greatest heat, the color red, and the season of summer.

All candle magic comes under fire's powers.

WATER

Water is the element of purification, the subconscious mind, love and the emotions.

Just as water is fluid, constantly changing, flowing from one level to another, so too are our emotions in a constant state of flux.

Water is the element of absorption and germination. The subconscious is symbolized by this element because it is rolling, always moving, like the sea which rests neither night or day.

Water magic involves pleasure, friendship, marriage, fertility, happiness, healing, sleep, dreaming, psychic acts, purification, and so on.

A ritual of water usually ends with an object being tossed or placed in or on a body of water.

This is a feminine element, and its color is the blue of deep,

deep water. It rules the West and autumn months of the year, when rain showers wash the Earth.

The magic of water is wrought with mirrors, the sea, fog and rain.

These, then, are the four elements. A thorough study of them can occupy a lifetime, but these are the basics.

Though it isn't necessary to call upon these elements or to work with them directly, it is beneficial to be aware of them and to remember them while working magic.

For actual workings with the elements, see the next four chapters.